The End Of Forgetting: AI Will Soon Remember Everything You Say

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For most of human history, conversation was temporary.

You could sit across from a friend at lunch, talk with your spouse in the kitchen, debate politics with coworkers, counsel someone at church or make an offhand remark—and unless someone deliberately wrote it down or recorded it, those words disappeared into memory.

That assumption is beginning to collapse.

A new generation of wearable artificial intelligence devices is being designed to accompany people throughout the day, listening to conversations and transforming them into transcripts, summaries, reminders and searchable personal histories.

Amazon's Bee wearable, for example, processes conversations throughout the day and uses them to understand a user's patterns, preferences and relationships. Amazon says the device processes conversations without retaining the original audio, but the information extracted from those conversations can still become part of the personalized AI experience.

Plaud's NotePin S can be worn on the body and is designed to record conversations, transcribe them and generate AI summaries.

Limitless developed an AI pendant around an even more ambitious concept: record large portions of your day and allow artificial intelligence to organize, summarize and search what happened. Its system has allowed users to retain audio anywhere from a day to indefinitely, depending on their settings.

The convenience is obvious.

Never take meeting notes again.

Never forget what someone promised.

Ask your AI what your doctor told you six months ago.

Search a conversation from last year.

Automatically generate a list of everything you agreed to accomplish this week.

But underneath that convenience is a much larger transformation.

We are moving from the Internet remembering what you typed to artificial intelligence remembering what you said.

And that raises one of the most important privacy questions of the AI age:

Who controls the memory?

Your Digital Footprint Is About To Get Much Bigger

Americans already leave enormous trails of digital information.

Our phones know where we travel. Search engines know what interests us. Online retailers know what we purchase. Social networks know who our friends are. Apps can collect information about our habits, movements and preferences.

Wearable AI adds something enormously valuable to that profile:

our actual conversations.

What do you worry about?

What does your marriage look like?

What do you think about your employer?

What political opinions do you express privately?

Which medical problems are you discussing?

What are your financial concerns?

Who are you meeting?

What did you promise someone?

What subjects make you angry, frightened or excited?

Conversation contains information that people would never deliberately type into Facebook or enter into a Google search.

Yet increasingly, that information can be captured, converted into text, categorized and made searchable.

A searchable transcript is fundamentally different from a recording sitting forgotten on a hard drive.

AI can potentially identify names, subjects, dates, decisions and recurring themes across thousands of conversations.

What once required someone to listen through hundreds of hours of audio could eventually require a simple question:

"Show me every conversation in which this person criticized his employer."

That changes the value of the data dramatically.

The Person Being Recorded May Not Even Own The Device

There is another problem that receives far too little attention.

The purchaser of an AI wearable may have willingly agreed to being recorded.

Everyone standing around him did not.

Imagine walking into a business meeting and discovering that someone's necklace has been creating an AI transcript.

Or speaking privately with a friend whose wearable is quietly documenting the conversation.

Or a pastor counseling a church member.

A teacher speaking with a student.

Parents discussing family problems.

Employees complaining about management.

Limitless explicitly tells its users that they should notify people and obtain consent before recording them, and its pendant uses a visible recording light.

That is important protection.

But it also demonstrates the larger problem.

Technology now makes it remarkably easy for another person's device to turn your words into someone else's database.

And once the culture becomes accustomed to these devices, people may simply begin assuming that everything they say could be preserved.

The result could fundamentally alter human conversation.

Today's Promise Is Not Tomorrow's Guarantee

Many AI companies emphasize privacy protections.

Plaud says information sent to its AI providers for processing is subject to zero-data-retention arrangements and is not used by those providers to train their models.

Amazon says Bee does not retain the raw conversational audio it processes.

Those safeguards matter.

But privacy concerns are larger than whether one particular company currently stores one particular type of file.

Companies can be acquired.

Terms of service can change.

Accounts can be compromised.

Governments can issue legal demands.

Employees can misuse access.

Databases can be breached.

And even when the original audio disappears, information derived from the conversation may still have tremendous value.

Bee's own privacy notice, for example, describes potential permissions involving contacts, calendars, messages, microphones, sensors, health and fitness information and other phone features depending upon what the user enables.

That illustrates where personal AI is heading.

Not simply toward knowing one conversation.

Toward understanding the context of your life.

We May Build The Surveillance System Ourselves

The most remarkable aspect of this revolution is that nobody needs to force these devices upon us.

We will buy them because they are useful.

That is how many of the most powerful surveillance technologies have already entered society.

We voluntarily carry GPS trackers because smartphones are convenient.

We installed microphones in our homes because voice assistants were useful.

We put internet-connected cameras at our doors because they improved security.

Now we may begin wearing artificial intelligence capable of documenting our everyday lives because we don't want to take notes.

There may never be a government announcement declaring that every conversation will be recorded.

Instead, millions of individuals may gradually construct that infrastructure themselves.

One device at a time.

One meeting at a time.

One conversation at a time.

For decades we worried about a future in which computers would know everything about us.

We may have misunderstood how that future would arrive.

It may not begin with a surveillance camera mounted on every wall.

It may begin with a small AI device pinned to someone's shirt.

The most consequential feature of tomorrow's artificial intelligence may not be that it can speak to us.

It may be that it never forgets what we said.

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